RAJASTHANI COLLECTION

NO. 03



THAR DESERT, RAJASTHAN

Ker Sangri

Wild Desert Berries & Beans
A Rare Delicacy of the Thar Desert

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Ker Sangri

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Ker Sangri

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DISCLAIMER

Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

A Dish That Exists Nowhere Else

Of every dish in this collection, ker sangri may be the most genuinely unique to Rajasthan — built from two ingredients that grow wild, and almost exclusively, in the arid Thar Desert: ker, small tart berries from the Capparis decidua shrub, and sangri, slender beans from the khejri tree, itself so significant to desert ecology and Rajasthani culture that it's recognized as the state tree. Neither ingredient is cultivated in any conventional agricultural sense — both are foraged from wild desert plants adapted to survive with minimal water.

Because fresh ker and sangri are only available briefly, both are traditionally sun-dried after harvest and stored for use throughout the year, another example of the resourceful preservation techniques that define Rajasthani desert cooking. The dried ingredients are rehydrated before cooking, then simmered with a distinctive blend of spices, dried mango powder, and often dried red chilies to create a tangy, intensely flavored dish unlike anything else in Indian cuisine.

Ker sangri holds genuine cultural weight beyond its unusual ingredients — it represents the deep, specific relationship between Rajasthani communities and their harsh desert environment, a dish that couldn't have developed anywhere else in India, and one that Rajasthanis living elsewhere often describe as carrying an almost irreplaceable taste of home.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

A Dish That Exists Nowhere Else, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Made from ker berries and sangri beans, both wild plants native specifically to Rajasthan's Thar Desert and found nowhere else in Indian cuisine in this combination. The khejri tree, source of sangri, is recognized as Rajasthan's state tree, reflecting its deep ecological and cultural significance. Both ingredients are traditionally sun-dried after a brief wild harvest and stored for year-round use, exemplifying Rajasthani preservation techniques. Considered an almost irreplaceable taste of home by many Rajasthanis, given how specific and unique the dish is to the region.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

8h soak	25m	4	Med
PREP TIME	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Large bowl, for soaking
- Kadai or wide pan
- Wooden spoon

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Ker sangri keeps refrigerated for up to a week — its tangy, dry preparation style makes it more shelf-stable than most fresh vegetable curries. It's also commonly made in larger batches specifically because it keeps so well, another echo of the dish's roots in a preservation-conscious desert cuisine.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the dish

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Dried sangri (khejri beans)	1 cup	100 g	1 katori
Dried ker (desert berries)	½ cup	50 g	½ katori
Water, for soaking	as needed	as needed	as needed
Mustard oil	4 tbsp	60 ml	4 chammach
Asafoetida (hing)	pinch	pinch	chutki bhar
Cumin seeds	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Dried red chilies	3–4	3–4	3–4
Turmeric powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Red chili powder	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Coriander powder	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Amchur (dried mango powder)	1½ tsp	4.5 g	1½ chammach
Fennel seeds	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Salt	1 tsp	6 g	to taste

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Ker and sangri are genuinely difficult to find outside Rajasthan and are typically sold dried, specifically imported by Indian grocers with a Rajasthani clientele, or ordered online from Indian specialty retailers. There is no true substitute that replicates their unique flavor — this is a dish worth seeking out authentic ingredients for specifically, rather than approximating with other vegetables, as the ker and sangri themselves are the entire point of the dish.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Rehydrating the Ker and Sangri

01 SOAK SEPARATELY

Soak the dried sangri and dried ker in separate bowls of water overnight, or for at least 8 hours, until softened and rehydrated.

02 RINSE THOROUGHLY

Drain and rinse both several times with fresh water — this removes excess dust and any residual bitterness from the drying process.



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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Rehydrating the Ker and Sangri, continued

Chef tip. don't skip the thorough rinsing — dried wild ingredients like these can carry more grit and dust than commercially cultivated vegetables.

COOKING CHECKPOINT

Both ker and sangri should feel notably softened and plump after soaking, no longer hard or brittle, before you proceed to cooking.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Cooking Ker Sangri

03 TEMPER THE SPICES

Heat mustard oil in a kadai and add asafoetida, cumin seeds, and dried red chilies, letting them sizzle until fragrant.

04 ADD THE KER AND SANGRI

Add the drained, rinsed ker and sangri, along with turmeric, chili powder, and coriander powder, stirring to coat evenly.



05 COOK UNTIL TENDER

Cook uncovered on medium heat for 15–18 minutes, stirring frequently, until the ker and sangri are tender and any excess moisture has evaporated.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Cooking Ker Sangri, continued

06 FINISH WITH AMCHUR AND FENNEL

Stir in the amchur, fennel seeds, and salt, cooking for a final 3–4 minutes to let the tangy flavor develop fully.

Texture and flavor indicator. finished ker sangri should be dry, not saucy, with a distinctly tangy, slightly sharp flavor from the amchur balancing the dish's inherent earthiness.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Skipping the thorough soaking and rinsing steps is the most common mistake, leaving the dish gritty or overly bitter. Take the full soaking time and rinse well before cooking.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served as part of a Rajasthani thali alongside dal baati, roti, or rice.
- A specialty dish often served to guests as a point of regional pride, given its unique, hard-to-find ingredients.

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How to serve, continued

Family Style

- A distinctive side dish that adds real regional character to a Rajasthani meal spread.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Flavor Right

- Thorough soaking and rinsing genuinely make the difference between a gritty, overly sharp dish and a properly balanced one.
- Amchur's tang is essential to balancing ker's natural bitterness — don't skimp on it.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- Ker sangri is traditionally made in larger batches specifically because it keeps so well — a genuinely practical make-ahead dish.
- Source dried ker and sangri in advance if you don't have a nearby specialty grocer, as they may need to be ordered online.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some Rajasthani cooks add a small amount of dried mango pieces (amchoor slices) alongside the powder for extra bursts of tang throughout the dish — an advanced variation for those who love the flavor.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

145 kcal	4 g	14 g	9 g	6 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with ghee and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Gluten, Mustard. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Ker Sangri with Kachri	some households add another wild desert ingredient, dried kachri (a wild melon), for extra complexity.
Ker Sangri Ki Launji	a sweeter, more pickle-like preparation of the same core ingredients.
Simple Ker Sangri	a version relying purely on amchur and chili, without fennel, for those who prefer a more direct tang.

Where can I buy ker and sangri?

Specialty Indian grocers, particularly those serving a Rajasthani community, or online Indian specialty retailers are the most reliable sources — they're rarely found at general Indian grocery stores.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Can I substitute other vegetables?

Not really — ker sangri's entire identity comes from these specific wild desert ingredients; substituting would essentially create a different dish.

Why is my ker sangri very bitter?

Ker retains natural bitterness even after soaking; thorough rinsing and a generous amount of amchur help balance this — some bitterness is expected and traditional.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Ker	small tart berries from a wild desert shrub, native to the Thar Desert.
Sangri	slender beans from the khejri tree, Rajasthan's state tree.
Khejri	a hardy desert tree of deep ecological and cultural significance in Rajasthan.
Amchur	dried mango powder, essential for balancing this dish's flavor.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Ker Sangri

8h soak	25m
PREP TIME	COOK TIME
4	Med
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

DISH

Dried sangri	100 g
Dried ker	50 g
Water	as needed
Mustard oil	60 ml
Asafoetida	pinch
Cumin seeds	4 g
Dried red chilies	3–4
Turmeric powder	1.5 g
Red chili powder	3 g
Coriander powder	3 g
Amchur	4.5 g
Fennel seeds	3 g
Salt	6 g

METHOD

01 **Soak separately.** Soak the dried sangri and dried ker in separate bowls of water overnight, or for at least 8 hours, until softened and rehydrated.

02 **Rinse thoroughly.** Drain and rinse both several times with fresh water — this removes excess dust and any residual bitterness from the drying process.

03 **Temper the spices.** Heat mustard oil in a kadai and add asafoetida, cumin seeds, and dried red chilies, letting them sizzle until fragrant.

04 **Add the ker and sangri.** Add the drained, rinsed ker and sangri, along with turmeric, chili powder, and coriander powder, stirring to coat evenly.

05 **Cook until tender.** Cook uncovered on medium heat for 15–18 minutes, stirring frequently, until the ker and sangri are tender and any excess moisture has evaporated.

06 **Finish with amchur and fennel.** Stir in the amchur, fennel seeds, and salt, cooking for a final 3–4 minutes to let the tangy flavor develop fully.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Dried sangri	100 g	☐ Dried ker	50 g
☐ Mustard oil	60 ml	☐ Asafoetida	pinch
☐ Cumin seeds	4 g	☐ Dried red chilies	3–4
☐ Turmeric powder	1.5 g	☐ Red chili powder	3 g
☐ Coriander powder	3 g	☐ Amchur	4.5 g
☐ Fennel seeds	3 g	☐ Salt	6 g

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